

THE SAME HOUSE TWICE

THE SPINE, v1.0

Pipeline step 1. What actually happened, hour by hour, and what Ally can lawfully reach, from whom, on which day. **No prose. No voice. No cold open.** Those are step 4.

Source: C8 from the 2026-08-25 reader test, the only surviving premise both readers reacted to. Stephen: *"Interesting, there may be something in this."* Trish: *"Not bad at all. This might be interesting."* Its reader-tested sentence, kept intact as the thing being developed:

Two deaths at the same address in Highcliff, eleven years apart. Both certified natural. Both by the same doctor. The house passed twice, and both times to the same man, who is the doctor's brother-in-law. The doctor is not a killer and has never taken a penny. He is a man who signed for two deaths he didn't look at closely, because he was asked to by a family he liked, as he has done a dozen times for people who were kind to him. There is a third person living at that address now. She is eighty-one, and her will changed four months ago.

Status: not canon, not a pass. Written to be attacked at step 3.

Title. *The Same House Twice*. One title, not a list. Fable may earn a better one from the prose.

o. THE CARE LINE

Per bible §1.4b.

Episode. An eighty-one-year-old woman is being looked after by a man who has done this twice before, and both times the person died. Nobody can prove it, and she does not want to be told. The one person who could prove it loses everything by saying so.

Phase One, leads 1 to 6. Somebody says a woman is going to die and will not say it on the record. Nobody knows whether she is a crank or the only person paying attention. The house itself is the only thing anyone can check.

Phase Two, leads 7 to 11. Two people died in that house and both deaths were signed off correctly. Nobody knows whether the man who inherited is kind or patient. The doctor who signed both of them is still alive and still practising.

Phase Three, leads 12 to 16. A man moves in on a date that is already fixed, and both times before, that is when it started. Nobody knows whether telling her helps her or hands her to him. There is no version where somebody is not badly hurt by what Ally does.

PART A. WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

Years are counted back from the game's now. The house is **14 Orchard Steps, Highcliff Heights**.

A1. The first one, Year –16

When	What
Y–22	Colin Meade, then 32, marries Ruth Yardley . Her brother is Dr Alan Yardley , then 49, a GP at the Highcliff practice. Colin is the doctor's brother-in-law from this day, and that is the whole mechanism
Y–19	Colin, a gardener, starts doing the garden at 14 Orchard Steps for Edith Larkin , 76, widow, heart failure, on digoxin. Her daughter Marion lives abroad
Y–19 to Y–16	Two and a half years. Garden, then shopping, then the bins, then the boxes she cannot read. He is not pretending. He is genuinely good at it, which is why nobody was ever suspicious of a man who was doing exactly what he appeared to be doing
Y–17, Mar	Edith changes her will at a solicitor's, alone and competent, leaving the house to Colin. She has a daughter she sees twice a year and a man who comes every day
Y–16, Jan	Colin moves into the annexe "so she isn't on her own at night"
Y–16, Feb	Over about ten days he raises her dose. She is nauseated, unsteady, confused. She tells Marion on the telephone that the lamps have gone green. Marion thinks it is a strange thing to say and thinks nothing else about it
Y–16, 3 Mar	Dr Yardley visits twice that fortnight. He sees a woman with heart failure who is deteriorating, which is what he expects to see. He does not order a blood level, because you order one when you suspect one
Y–16, 7 Mar, 06:10	Colin telephones the practice. Edith died in the night
Y–16, 7 Mar, 09:40	Yardley attends. He certifies heart failure. He attended her in her last illness so he may certify, and there is no referral. He is not wrong about the disease. He is wrong about the dose
Y–16, Mar	Cremation, per Edith's wishes
Y–15	Probate. The house passes to Colin. He sells it fourteen months later

A2. The gap, Year –15 to Year –6

When	What
Y–15 to Y–9	Colin spends it. Not lavishly. Over nine years, on nothing anybody would notice
Y–9	Ruth dies of cancer. Colin nurses her at home for eleven months. Alan Yardley watches his brother-in-law care for his sister better than he could himself. △ Ally will ask whether that was a third one. The episode does not answer it. See Part K
Y–6	The money is gone. Colin takes driving and handyman work back on Orchard Steps, where he is a known face from a decade ago. He did not choose the street again. He returned to the only street where he already had a character reference

A3. The second one, Year –5

When	What
Y–7	Gordon Pace , 74, buys 14 Orchard Steps. Widower, no children, no siblings, one nephew he has not spoken to in twenty years. Atrial fibrillation, on digoxin. Dr Yardley's patient, because Yardley has that street
Y–6	Colin does Gordon's garden. Then everything else. Eighteen months this time, not two and a half years
Y–5, May	Gordon changes his will. House to Colin
Y–5, Sep	Colin moves in
Y–5, 12 Oct	Gordon dies at home. Same drug, same presentation, same doctor
Y–5, 12 Oct	★ Yardley signs it, and this is the difference between the two deaths: this time he knows. He does not examine, he does not refer, and he goes home and does not sleep. He has been waiting five years for somebody to knock
Y–5, Oct	Burial, Havenbay. Not cremated. Colin is executor, so Colin holds the paperwork
Y–4	Probate. The house passes to Colin for the second time, and the register records it
Y–3	Colin sells 14 Orchard Steps to Winnie Aspinall , 78

A4. Now

When	What
Y-3	Winnie buys the house. Widow, 78, no children. She made her own money and bought into Highcliff late, so she has a street full of neighbours who have never once knocked. The only person on Orchard Steps who is kind to her is the man who sold it to her
Y-3 to now	Colin does her garden. Then her shopping. Then, this year, her medicines. She has atrial fibrillation and is on digoxin. Dr Yardley is her GP
4 months ago	Winnie changes her will at a solicitor's, alone, entirely competent, leaving the house to Colin. ★ She is not being tricked and she has not been groomed into anything she does not mean. She has a second cousin she has met twice and a man who comes every day, and she has decided the man should have it. She is right to feel that, and it is what kills her
6 weeks ago	Colin puts his own flat on the market. The money from the sale goes into the purchase chain, so he has nowhere to go back to. He has burned his own boat and that is why he cannot simply stop
~2 months ago	Josie Renn , 46, of Highcliff Home Care, is assigned to Winnie twice a week. She was Gordon Pace's carer five years ago, on the same street, for the same agency, because three agencies serve that district and have for thirty years. She recognises Colin. She says nothing for two months, because she has nothing to say
9 days ago	The board comes down off Colin's flat. Josie knows what happens next because she watched it happen
Day 1	Josie telephones the show. She gives her name. She refuses to be recorded and refuses to put anything in writing. Ally has notes and nothing else
Day 18	Completion. Colin moves into 14 Orchard Steps. The date is on a public register and was fixed before Ally heard the name

What he does and why it is not a plan. He is not a compulsive killer and he does not have a method he is proud of. **He does this when the money runs out.** Twice in sixteen years. He chooses people whose absence nobody will argue about, he is genuinely kind to them for a year or two, and then he is out of money again.

★ He is not hiding. Every single thing he has done is on a public register, correctly recorded, and has been for years. Nobody read it.

PART B. WHY NOBODY NOTICED

One causal version each. Nothing here requires anybody to be lazy.

Question	Answer
Two deaths at one address, eleven years apart, same doctor. No flag?	Nothing cross-references deaths by property. A certificate is indexed to a person. There is no beneficiary field on it, and probate is a different office in a different year
A doctor certifying two deaths that both benefit his brother-in-law?	He certified two patients he had attended in their last illness, which is what the great majority of deaths are and requires no referral. There is no system that asks who inherits
The solicitors?	Two firms, eleven years apart. A conveyancer acts on the transaction in front of them and nobody reads back sixteen years on a title
The neighbours?	Highcliff. Gated terraces, private security, and eleven years
The pharmacy?	Repeat prescriptions collected at a rate that does not match the prescribed dose is visible in a dispensing record and invisible to a person handing over a bag
★ The doctor?	★ He did notice. On the second one. He did not repress it, he decided not to look at it, and he has known for five years that one day somebody would ask him. That is why he is the reversal and why he is almost relieved

The thesis, and it is the show's: *the record is wrong, and somebody is still living with the consequence.* Here the record is not even wrong. **It is complete, accurate, public and permanent, and no human being ever read two lines of it next to each other.**

PART C. THE ACCESS LEDGER

★ Co. NOTHING HERE IS THE ONLY ROUTE

This section exists because of what killed the last premise. No Fixed Address claimed one lawful route to its jeopardy and its own ledger contained a second. The rule that killed it is now pre-flight objection 11.

Every route below is open from early, and none of them is closed off to force the plot. The episode does not get its tension from Ally being unable to reach people. **It gets it from every route costing somebody something,** and from the fact that the two cheapest routes are the two that hand Winnie to Colin.

C1. What Ally can lawfully reach

Day	Item	Held by	Authority	What it gives
1	Josie's account	Josie	Hers, given freely, and she will not be recorded	A name, a street, a date, and no evidence whatsoever
1	The title history of 14 Orchard Steps	Public register	★ R14: property transfers publicly searchable, permanently	Sixteen years on one page. The same name twice. This is the entry point and it is lawfully spotless
1	The pending sale and its completion date	Public register	R14	Day 18 , and the same move he made in Y-16 and Y-5
2	Colin's own flat sale	Public register	R14	He has nowhere to go back to
2	Del Cruz	HCPD	She can hear it	Del can do nothing on a property search and a care worker who will not be recorded, and she says so . She can act the moment there is a referral
3	Winnie Aspinall	Herself	Her own door	She is sharp, funny, wealthy and entirely uninterested in being rescued
3	Dr Alan Yardley	Himself	He agrees to see her	★ The reversal. He can be reached on day three and the whole episode is what it costs to get him to speak
4	Marion Larkin	Herself	Hers	<i>"She told me the lamps had gone green."</i> Sixteen years of a daughter not knowing what she was carrying
4	Colin Meade	Himself	He is delighted to talk	Warm, open, nothing to hide, and he means it
5	Gordon Pace's grave	Public	Public record	He was buried, not cremated. Which matters, and Colin did not choose it

Day	Item	Held by	Authority	What it gives
6	Highcliff Home Care	The agency	Josie's employer, and Ally asking costs Josie her job	Who attended Gordon and who attends Winnie

C2. What is closed, and stays closed

Item	Why
Both death certificates	R11: restricted to next of kin, executors and legal representatives for thirty years. Marion can obtain Edith's. Gordon has no next of kin, and his executor is Colin , so the second certificate is held by the man who caused it
The pharmacy dispensing record for Gordon	Commercial data, R8, seven years , so it exists for five more months and belongs to the pharmacy. Police can obtain it. Ally cannot
The pharmacy record for Edith	Gone. R8 expired nine years ago. The first death cannot be proved and never will be
Edith's remains	Cremated
Medical records for either deceased	R10 , next of kin only, never Ally in her own right
Voss Group street cameras on Orchard Steps	Private, theirs, R7 thirty-one days . What Colin is doing this month is on them and expires during the episode. Police can flag it. Ally cannot have it
Winnie's will	Not public until probate, which is the thing everybody is trying to prevent

★ The retention rules are doing dramatic work rather than obstructing it. The first death is unprovable, the second is inside the window by five months, and the third has not happened. **Three deaths, three completely different evidential situations, all produced by canon that was ruled two days before this premise existed.**

PART D. THE ANTAGONIST'S LEAST-COST LEDGER

From	His cheapest action	Why
Always	Kindness, in public, for years	It is not a disguise. It is the actual method, and it is why two coroners were never involved
When Ally appears	Be delighted	He invites her in, answers everything, and shows her the garden. He has nothing to hide because there is nothing in the house to find
When Ally persists	★ Tell Winnie first.	His weapon is not violence, it is an eighty-one-year-old woman's dignity . He tells her a podcaster thinks she is a confused old lady being taken advantage of. Winnie closes every door in Havenbay and rings the show's lawyers herself
Could he just stop?	No, and that is what the flat sale buys. He has sold his home into the chain. Stopping does not undo two deaths, and Ally is now looking at Orchard Steps whatever he does	
If publicly named	Leave, and leave Winnie alive	Which is a win, and it is also the end of any case for Edith or Gordon

He never predicts the plot and he is never clever. He is a patient man who is right about which absences nobody argues about, and he was right about that long before he hurt anybody.

PART E. THE CLOCK

Day 18. Completion. He moves in.

It is dated, it is on a public register, it was fixed six weeks before Ally heard his name, and **it does not move because of anything she does** until she forces it to.

Both times before, moving in is when it started: seven weeks for Edith, five for Gordon. **△ That is a pattern and it is presented as one. Nothing is proved by it and no reversal rests on it.** Day-stamped, case-born, pause-safe. The session-contained window stays parked per the clock convention.

And a second clock nobody controls: the Voss cameras on the public street hold thirty-one days. What he is doing this month exists until it does not.

PART F. SIXTEEN LEADS

Phase One, leads 1 to 6 — a house

#	What the player does	What changes
1	Josie's call	A woman is going to die, somebody knows it, and there is nothing on the record
2	The title history	Sixteen years on one page and the same name on it twice
3	Del	Del confirms both deaths were certified and neither was referred, and that she can do nothing without one. She names what would change that
4	The pending sale	Day 18. And the same move, twice before. Decision 1
5	The two dead	Edith Larkin and Gordon Pace, sixteen and five years, one drug, one doctor
6	The doctor's name on both	Alan Yardley, still practising, and Winnie Aspinall's GP

Midpoint, lead 7 — the green lamps

Marion Larkin, sixteen years and a continent away, says the thing she has carried without knowing she was carrying it. **The player stops investigating a property and starts investigating a poisoning.**

★ **This is the merge board's best shot at the project's rank-one open question.** The player has been assembling public paper that individually means nothing. One sentence from a daughter re-reads all of it. **If a reconstruction can change what a player believes, it happens here.**

Phase Two, leads 8 to 11 — the man who signed

#	What the player does	What changes
8	Reach Marion properly	She is owed a decision she did not ask for. Decision 2
9	Colin	Warm, open, delighted, and he shows Ally the garden
10	Yardley	He has been waiting five years. He will say it, and he says what it costs
11	The price	A dozen other signatures, a career, and his dead sister's husband. Decision 3

Phase Three, leads 12 to 16 — seventeen days

#	What the player does	What changes
12	Winnie	She will not be rescued, and she is not wrong to refuse
13	Colin tells her first, or Ally does	Either way the doors shut
14	The referral	Whatever Yardley gave becomes police work: the dispensing record, the grave, the cameras
15	Completion is in two days	Decision 4
16	Day 18	Somebody moves into 14 Orchard Steps, or nobody does

PART G. THE FOUR DECISIONS

#	Lead	Class	Choice	Rejoins
1	4	A	Winnie first, or the doctor first	7
2	8	B	Tell Marion her mother may have been killed, or verify first	10
3	11	C	Publish what Yardley is, or protect him to get the one thing that saves Winnie	14
4	15	A	Broadcast Colin's name before completion, or let Del move quietly	close

Gate arithmetic: four decisions · two Class A · one Class C · rejoins of 3, 2, 3, 1 · no fork opens before the current branch rejoins · leads 7, 10 and 14 shared.

Decision 1 · lead 4 · Class A

Winnie first. She hears it from Ally rather than from Colin, which is the only version where she hears it from someone with no reason to lie. She will also tell him that afternoon, and Highcliff closes. **The doctor first.** Ally goes straight at the one person who can end it, and spends three days on him while an eighty-one-year-old woman is not told that the man doing her shopping has done this twice.

Neither is obviously right. Irreversible: Winnie's first impression of Ally, or three days of her not knowing.

Decision 2 • lead 8 • Class B

Tell Marion. She has standing as next of kin that Ally will never have, she can obtain her mother's certificate, and she can push a coroner. She will also spend the rest of her life on this whether Ally is right or wrong.

Verify first. Ally protects a woman from sixteen years of grief being reopened on a guess, and loses the only person with standing.

Irreversible: what Marion now knows, or the standing Ally did not use.

Decision 3 • lead 11 • Class C

★ **The episode's moral centre, and it is a real trade.**

Publish what he is. A doctor who signed a dozen deaths he did not look at is a public-interest story and it is true, and it is arguably the bigger story. He will not then help her, and without him there is no referral.

Protect him. Ally gets the one thing that saves Winnie, and buries a story about a man who is still signing certificates this week.

Irreversible: a doctor's dozen other signatures going unexamined, or Winnie.

Decision 4 • lead 15 • Class A

Broadcast his name. Colin leaves and Winnie lives. Edith and Gordon stay exactly where they are, permanently, and Winnie learns from a podcast what her friend was. **Let Del move quietly.** The dispensing record, the exhumation and the cameras make a case for Gordon that might hold. Colin is in that house for two more days.

Irreversible: the case, or the two days.

Counterfactual

Remove every decision and Colin moves in on Day 18, Winnie dies within two months, Marion never learns what the green lamps were, and Yardley signs a third certificate. **Named people's outcomes change on every branch, in both directions.**

PART H. THE THIRTEEN-OBJECTION PRE-FLIGHT

1. Why was the decisive material not found at the time? Nothing cross-references a death against a property, a beneficiary or a previous death, so there was never a moment at which anybody was supposed to look. Part B answers each institution individually.

2. Does the antagonist act in his own interest at every point? Yes, and his interest is always the cheap ordinary thing: kindness for years, delight when asked, and an old woman's dignity used as a shield.

3. Would a real person actually do the small thing this needs them to do? A daughter remembers a strange sentence from a phone call sixteen years ago; a doctor certifies a patient he has been attending; an eighty-one-year-old leaves her house to the man who comes every day instead of a cousin she has met twice.

4. **Is the motive one an ordinary reader accepts without argument?** Houses.
5. **Is any discovery a coincidence wearing a coat?** △ **One, and it is answered rather than removed:** Josie attended both Gordon and Winnie. Three agencies serve that district and have for thirty years, so the same carers see the same streets for decades. **If step 3 does not accept that, Josie is replaced and the tip comes from somewhere else.**
6. **Does a reader with no context understand every word?** In the spine no; in the opening, **not one procedural or clinical word** — see Part I.
7. **Can a reader hold the cast in their head on one pass?** △ **Eight named people is too many for an opening. Part I sets the cap.**
8. **Is it clear what the crime is, immediately?** A man is kind to old people until they leave him the house, and he is doing it again to a woman who is alive right now.
9. **Can Ally source everything she says she knows?** Every fact in Part C traces to a public register, a person who chose to speak, or something the police did and told her.
10. **Does anything break its own rules?** Not found. **The recording law is used deliberately: Josie refuses to be recorded, so Ally opens the episode holding nothing.**
11. ★ **If the premise claims a route is the only one, find the second route. ★ It claims none.** Part Co is explicit: every route is open from lead 3 and the tension is cost, not closure. **This is the objection that killed the last premise and it is designed against here.**
12. **Is the stake a body, freedom, family, identity or present danger?** A living woman with a date on it, two unprovable deaths, and a daughter's sixteen years.
13. **Does anything decisive rest on a small number?** △ **Watch this one.** The seven-week and five-week intervals are presented as pattern and prove nothing; the dispensing-rate gap is corroboration; **the reversal is a person saying it out loud.** If any draft lets the case turn on counting tablets, that draft is wrong.
- The question that is not on the list.** The antagonist is a person the audience is in a room with by lead 9, and his weapon is charm.
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PART I. WHAT THE PRE-FLIGHT CAUGHT

Catch 1, objection 7. Eight named people. Ally, Del, Colin, Yardley, Winnie, Marion, Josie, plus two dead. **Opening cap: four names.** Ally, Winnie, Colin, and one of Josie or Yardley. Del, Marion and the second name arrive after the first minute. Edith and Gordon can be "the woman before her" and "the man before that" for as long as the prose can hold it.

Catch 2, objection 6. Banned from the opening: **digoxin · therapeutic window · toxicity · certification · coroner · referral · probate · conveyancing · completion · dispensing · executor · next of kin.** Permitted: *her heart pills · the house · the will · the doctor · the garden · her shopping · he moves in on the eighteenth · the lamps had gone green.*

Catch 3, objection 5. Josie attending both Gordon and Winnie is the one coincidence, and it is defended rather than hidden. **It is the first thing to give up if step 3 pushes.**

Catch 4, objection 13. The interval pattern is the trap this premise carries. It reads as arithmetic and it must never carry a proof. **Flagged for every draft, not just this one.**

Catch 5, and it is not in the twelve or the thirteen. △ **The premise has no body at the top of the episode.** Everything we have learned says murder must be explicit in the opening, and here the murder that matters has not happened yet and the two that have are eleven and sixteen years cold.

My read: this is the premise's biggest risk and possibly its biggest asset. *A murder that has not happened yet* is the one opening shape this project has never tried, it is present-tense jeopardy by construction, and it answers "no jeopardy, too safe" more directly than a body does. **But it is unproven and it is exactly the kind of thing a spoken test exists to settle. It should be the thing the reader check is actually asking about.**

PART J. RULING QUESTIONS

Asked, not invented, per §2.3.2 standing practice.

#	Question	What turns on it	Recommendation
1	Who may certify a death in Havenbay without referral to the coroner, and what triggers a referral?	The entire premise	The attending doctor in the last illness may certify; referral is triggered by violence, unknown cause, or no attending doctor. This is the standard shape and none of the three deaths trips it
2	Can a body be exhumed in Havenbay, on whose authority, and on what evidence?	Leads 14 to 16, and whether Gordon is provable at all	Left to Stephen. If exhumation is unavailable, Gordon rests on the dispensing record alone and the ending gets harder, which may be better
3	What does a pharmacy dispensing record contain, and who may obtain one?	Corroboration for Gordon, and its five remaining months under R8	Left to Stephen. Recommend: police on a referral, never Ally
4	Does a competently made will survive its beneficiary being convicted of the death?	The close, and whether Winnie's cousin or nobody gets the house	Recommend the ordinary forfeiture rule. Low stakes for the spine, matters for the last line

Carried over and still unresolved from the parked premise: §2.3.1 and §2.3.1b disagree on whether Tip Line audio may be published. **Not needed here, because this episode deliberately does not use**

PART K. RISKS RECORDED

1.  **Representation, and this is the reason to take it.** The victims are a woman of 79, a man of 76 and a woman of 81. **The danger is not an intimate partner and the victims are not young women.** Set beside the parked premise and the retained viaduct seed, this pulls the four-episode set out of the pattern the genre research names instead of deeper into it.
 2. **The elderly-victim trap.** Old people are easy to write as objects. **Winnie is the answer and she has to be genuinely good:** sharp, funny, rich, rude, and right that she is being patronised. **The woman Ally is trying to save is the obstacle.** If Winnie is written as a victim waiting, the episode is dead.
 3. **No body at the top.** Part I catch 5. Unproven, and the reader check should be pointed straight at it.
 4. **The third one, unasked.** Colin nursed Yardley's sister for eleven months and she died. **Ally will ask. The episode must not answer it,** and if the episode feels overloaded, this is the first thing to cut.
 5. **Havenbay necessity, and it is thin in the honest way.** ★ **Highcliff's defining feature is privacy sold as a service:** gated terraces, private security, streets where nobody knocks. A man caring for an old woman behind a gate is invisible there in a way he would not be in Rivermouth, and the Voss cameras watching the public street mean the evidence exists and belongs to someone else. **That is real, and it is not the whole claim.** Relocate this to another wealthy district in another city and most of it survives. Recorded rather than dressed up.
 6. **Still unrun:** the evidence-turn test. Lead 7 is where this premise would demonstrate it.
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PART L. PRODUCTION ENVELOPE

- **Sixteen leads, three phases, four decisions, one Class C.**
 - **Existing cast:** Ally, Del. **New speaking portraits:** Colin, Winnie, Yardley. Josie and Marion can be voice-only or single-pose. **Three new portraits, same as the parked premise.**
 - **Locations:** the studio, one Highcliff terrace exterior and interior, a garden, a surgery, a cemetery.  **Highcliff is canon but has never been built.** This is the one real cost above the parked premise and it should be priced before commitment.
 - **No body is shown. No death is staged.** The mechanism is described twice and never depicted.
 - **Code, verified 2026-08-27:**  the lead counter is fixed and sixteen leads display correctly. 
`requiresFlag / forbidsFlag` supports the branches.  `CaseResolutionService.cs:12` still hardcodes
`EpisodeId = "e1_the_listener"`.
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NEXT

Step 3: ChatGPT attacks this spine. Point it at Part I catch 5 first (no body at the top), then Part B (why nobody noticed), then Part Co (whether any route is secretly closed).

Step 4: Fable writes one opening. Four names, the banned-vocabulary list, and Winnie written as a person who does not want saving.

Step 5: two questions, and this time with a third asked explicitly: does a murder that has not happened yet pull as hard as a body.